

CULTIVARS

- Rainbow
- Giant Fordhook

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 2 rows per bed spaced every 18" (45 cm) on the row

FERTILIZATION

- Swiss chard will stay a long time in the ground and therefore is amended with lots of compost, fresh or aged. The rule of thumb is to spread +/-1 inch (5 cm) all across the bed. When the biological activity is not optimal (cold or poor soils) add extra amendments of organic fertilizers like alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and/or pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Drip tape (2 per bed) or sprinkler

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Medium (24"-40")
- General: Average water needs, except during warm weather when more water is required to prevent wilting.

IMPLANTATION

We plan for 3 Swiss chard planting in the season and intend to harvest the plants over 14 weeks. This ensures continuous supply of new leaves harvested every week. Swiss chard is usually planted alongside kale, as the crops have almost identical management strategies.

EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- Broadfork
- 30" bed prep rake
- Popping tray
- Landscape fabric, staples, drip tape and fittings

TRANSPLANT ITINERARY

- Pass through with the broadfork.
- Remove large debris from the bed if needed (use flail mower, rake or manually remove the large chunks).
- Apply compost and/or amendments across the bed and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2.5" (6 cm). Since the bed is covered with landscape fabric, it doesn't need to be clean up with another pass of the rake.
- If installing drip tape, set out 4 lines per bed and start the system. Fix leaks at point that point, if any.
- Lay down landscape fabric and secured with staples every second step (5' or 1.5 m). It needs to be really tight.
- Use the popping tray to facilitate extraction and transplant the kale seedlings. Do not bury the plug (top should be even with soil level) and make sure to place them in the center of each hole. 1 person/100'bed is a good ratio for efficient workflow.
- Water the bed thoroughly the first time, keeping the soil moist for the first week after transplanting.

WEEDING

- No weeding required

PLANT PROTECTION

- If problematic, control flea beetles by covering plants with anti-insect netting and mini-tunnels so the net covers the 2 beds.
- Swiss Chard and Kale will benefit from monthly doses of boron and seaweed (or compost tea) applied foliarly. Plan to spray when spraying fresh beets.

HARVEST

- Chard is harvested by cutting off 2 to 3 leaves per plant, each leaf measuring between 6" and 9" (20 and 30 cm). Cut leaves at the bottom of the plant (in order to have longest stems possible) and place all the stems in the same direction in the harvest crate. Harvest equal amounts of Fordhook and Giant this way.
- Make bouquets of 6–7 stems by placing leaves of Fordhook on the inside (delicious) and leaves of Rainbow on the outside (beautiful), wrapping them with an elastic band. This will produce bouquets which are both lovely and tasty.
- Once all the bouquets are done, chop the end of the bundle with a sharp blade, making all the stems the same size.
- 1 person should harvest +/- 70 bunches per hour

CONDITIONING

- Swiss Chard is not always washed, but should be if harvested on hot days, in order to remove field heat.
- Dunk plants in cold water, shake out excess water and leave to dry for a few minutes. Place criss-cross in storage bin and identify the bin.

STORING

- Swiss chard is stored in a cold room kept at 35 °F (2 °C) and should not be stored for more than 4 days before being sold.